system. Herzog himself was taken aback. He learned about the shift in a grim early-morning phone call from Livni, and soon called Netanyahu from his north Tel Aviv home to concede defeat.

Nearly a year after the election, Amit Segal produced a telling report for Channel 2, based on interviews with Netanyahu's campaign managers. It opened with footage from a Likud focus group, where the party faithful admitted they were exhausted with the prime minister. "How many times can you vote for Bibi?" asked one young woman. "He's worn out. He should take a sabbatical," said another. But then the consultants asked their subjects to imagine Election Day. "You're lying under the blanket, the weather is terrible, you don't feel like going out to vote—but the race is close, and a left-wing government is possible. Who would you vote for?" Everyone sitting around the table gave the same answer. "Likud."

The campaign knew it couldn't win on the issues, so it didn't even try. Instead it focused on identity. It relentlessly portrayed Herzog and Livni (both bland centrists) as "the left," and reminded supporters that the Labor party had a long history of insulting *mizrahim*. It played off the excitement over the Joint List, with anonymous text messages that falsely claimed Herzog had promised to appoint an Arab minister. (I showed one to Tibi, who laughed: "Tell them I have no plans to become defense minister.")

And then it broadcast a sense of panic: come home to Likud, voters were warned, or right-wing rule will end, a message drummed home (again, via a text-message salvo) even as late as the afternoon of the vote. The strategy worked to perfection. Nearly 600,000 voters, fully 14 per cent of total turnout, came to the polls in the final two hours, compared to just 6 per cent in the previous election.

So, after a grueling three-month campaign, almost nothing had changed. Netanyahu would remain in office. The balance of power within the Knesset barely shifted. The "battle for Israel's soul" ended, like so many of Israel's recent battles, with an inconclusive ceasefire.

For all the events, the media appearances and get-out-the-vote campaigns, Herzog's strategy had ultimately been a simple one: he had tried to be the antithesis of Benjamin Netanyahu. Some of that was genetic. His demeanor was quiet and reserved, his voice nasal. After some coaching he tried to perk up his delivery, striding around the stage and punctuating his words with chopping gestures, but his style could still best be described as on the soporific side. He had barely mentioned Iran. There had been no talk